

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

March 2026 monthly report for software engineering leads and technology strategists

Based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Amazon, Wikipedia, Bing, and 20+ other engines, this report tracks language visibility and demand signals (engineers, courses, vendors), not language popularity. The TIOBE Index editorial rejects switching to LLM-based measurement because LLMs are trained on the internet, not on engineering. This report summarizes current rankings, largest movers, long-term trends, and practical portfolio implications.

Top language

Python (21.25%)

Largest gain

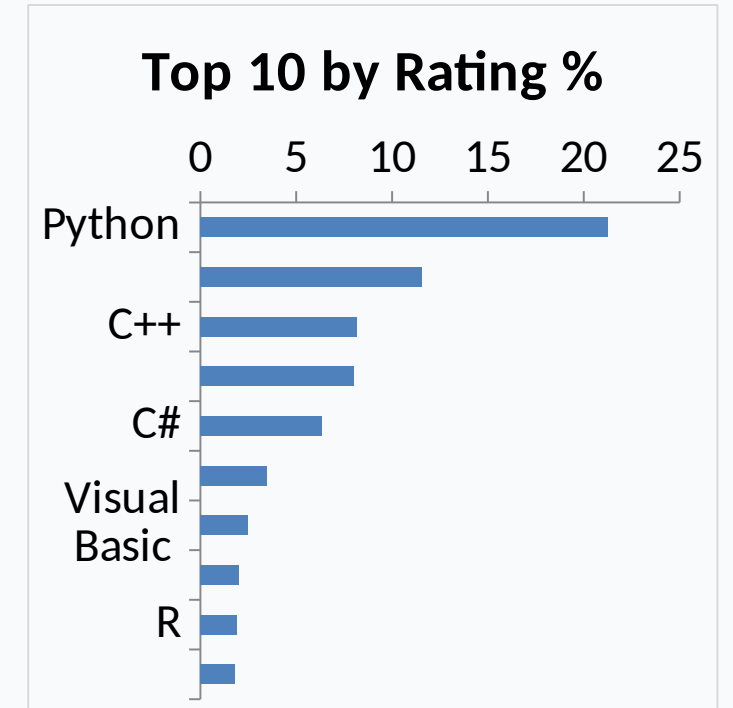
C (+2.02 pts)

Largest drop

Go (-1.49 pts)

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY Δ
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



Python leads but posts -2.59 pts YoY.
C climbs from #4 to #2 (+2.02 pts).
Top 4 (Python, C, C++, Java) = 48.97%.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Perl: 24 → 11 (+13 spots, +1.05%)

R: 16 → 9 (+7 spots, +0.94%)

Swift: 26 → 20 (+6 spots, +0.44%)

Gainers

Go: 7 → 16 (-9 spots, -1.49%)

C++: 2 → 3 (-1 spots, -2.90%)

Java: 3 → 4 (-1 spots, -2.37%)

Losers

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Lang	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python rose from unranked pre-1991 to #1 in 2026.
C stayed in top 2 at all nine points (1986–2026).
Java peaked at #1 (2006–2016) then declined to #4.
Lisp fell from #2 in 1986 to #26 in 2026.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Python leads all-time with 6 Language of the Year wins: 2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024
C# won twice recently (2023, 2025), signaling sustained .NET momentum.
Go won in 2016 but now ranks #16 after a sharp decline.
2017 winner is not available in the provided source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Portfolio balance: keep Python as strategic default, but hedge with C/C++ and Java to reduce concentration risk.

Resourcing: top 4 languages account for 48.97% of index activity; align hiring pipelines to this concentration.

Watchlist upgrades: track C acceleration (+2.02) and legacy rebounds (Perl +13 ranks, R +7) for niche talent demand.

Risk signal: investigate Go's drop (#7 → #16, -1.49) before committing long-horizon platform bets.

Roadmap action: run semiannual language portfolio reviews using external popularity and internal codebase metrics together.